

Product or Service

We propose an email scraper that aggregates “free food” announcements from Harvard listservs into a centralized finder. The tool will run through a dummy email account, connect to the house mailing lists at Harvard, and auto-populate a JSON database by identifying keywords within emails. Parsing pipelines will normalize the event data within the email once keywords are identified, and the database will feed into frontend where one must login using Google’s OAuth service (encrypted with HarvardKey and, therefore, only available to Harvard affiliates). The website will allow users to login with their email address and sign up for personalized notifications based on preferences.

Similar Existing Services

Outside of campus, To Good To Go is an app that lets people find food at heavy discounts (ie. pastries half off that are about to be thrown out).

There are also Twitter scrapers that sign up for free giveaways, but these are not adapted to college campuses since most Harvard clubs/events do not publicize on Twitter.

Free Food Alert is a similar service that was founded at Johns Hopkins University, which works by allowing club leaders to send out alerts if their club has leftover food after an event. Our service is differentiated by automatically scraping email lists without the need for any manual input.

Direct Stakeholders

Students (Users): Students are inundated with information overload. There are endless club, speaker, and food events on campus—but no centralized method for keeping track of events. Our product will alleviate students’ concerns of a “Fear of Missing Out (FOMO)” by making information equally accessible.

Clubs (Customers): Clubs publicize their events through listservs to moderate success. This product will take the endless stream of events and allow students to figure out what events are put on by what clubs, improving accessibility and visibility of different campus organizations.

Owners: There isn’t really a large monetization angle to this (clubs can be charged for advertising and exposure), but the owners and creators (us) receive kudos and widespread campus acclaim for creating a useful app.

Investors: If this does become a venture backable startup (unlikely due to scale and monetization issues), investors would want us to heavily scale this business and increase profitability. This

creates a value tension between Investors, Owners, and Users. The users and owners ideally want this app to provide as much utility as possible, while investors may want to increase profitability by adding a subscription (upselling), or charging clubs more to advertise.

Indirect Stakeholders

Harvard University Dining Services (Employees): More consumption of food drops leads to less populated dining halls and meal times. This may impact staff as well – if less students are eating at dining halls, there may be less demand for labour.

The Environment: Less food waste leads to less populated landfills and carbon emissions. Many food drops (especially those placed in strange locations) go untouched, and straight into the garbage the next day.

Harvard Administrative Board (Regulator): The Harvard Ad Board may be concerned about specific university privacy violations associated with a campus wide email scraper (ie. this gives access to email information to those not invited to listservs).

User Journey - Users (Students)

User Scenario and Goals:

- Name: John Doe is a sophomore at Harvard College.
- Backstory, Values & Motivations: John has just moved into his new House, and he wants to explore new clubs. He has a tough time finding events and information through email. He also gets hungry easily and eagerly awaits food drops.

User Actions, Thoughts, and Emotions

- While walking to class, John encounters in-person tabling outside the Science Center. He ignores it because he associates tabling with more email subscriptions (which he already struggles with).
- Later, he notices posters promoting “Dropped” with a QR code. The promise of free food grabs his attention immediately and he scans the QR code, taking him to the landing page.

Onboarding, Personalization, and Engagement

- John logs into Dropped using HarvardKey (OAuth).
- He sets preferences: clubs of interest, dietary restrictions, notification method (push vs email).
- Notifications give him confidence he won’t miss spontaneous events.
- The app’s interface makes it easy to discover food events and new clubs at a glance.

Action and Experience

- John receives a push notification: “Free sushi rolls at Quincy Dhall in 10 minutes.”
- He heads there, finds the food, and casually chats with the club members hosting the event.
- For him, this becomes not just about free food but a low-friction introduction to new communities.

Feedback and Retention

- John marks the event as “attended,” signaling interest in more Quincy-based events.
- He shares the event with a friend directly from the app, increasing adoption through network effects.
- Over time, John sees Dropped as crucial for event finding at Harvard.

Takeaways: Opportunities, Insights, Internal Ownership

- Opportunities: Campus buzz > email marketing, personalization > generic lists.
- Insights: Students crave filters, immediacy, and reliability.
- Internal Ownership: Success depends on keeping notifications accurate, timely, and trustworthy.
- Value Tensions:
 - Clubs vs Students: Clubs want maximum visibility, but students want relevance. Oversaturation risks recreating email fatigue.

- Users vs Investors: Students want free, open access with minimal ads. Investors may push for monetization (subscriptions, paid placements).

User Journey - Customers (Clubs)

Background

- Name: Harvard Institute of Politics
- Backstory, values, and motivations: The club engages undergraduate and graduate students to have discussions with speakers and political leaders. The club values differing viewpoints across campus to promote a more rich conversation and is motivated to have good turnout to be able to attract future speakers.
- What the club wants to do: The club is incentivized to get as much engagement as possible through offering food at its events.

Scenario

- There are often other events that occur at the same time as Harvard IOP speaker sessions. Our service, Dropped, lists overlapping events alphabetically by default, with an added paid service of being listed as a “Featured” event.
- The Harvard IOP wants to promote their event as a “Featured” event and is willing to pay for this service.

Actions, Thoughts, and Emotions

- The Harvard IOP needs to be authenticated to purchase the “Featured” event service.
- After authenticating, the Harvard IOP will be able to select which event they want to promote as “Featured” (if they have multiple events listed on Dropped).
- The Harvard IOP will then be transferred to a secure payment portal, where they will pay a fee to have their event be “Featured” on the Dropped homepage. The Dropped homepage will be automatically updated to reflect this after payment is received. Dropped users will have more visibility into these “Featured” events.
 - Critically, the IOP is price sensitive. They have a limited budget and a diverse set of advertising options (ie. email lists, instagram posts) which are free. This means that they are unlikely to pay for a service that is extremely expensive.

Takeaways

- Opportunities: The IOP’s need to incentivize engagement and attract members provides an opportunity to charge them for this service.
- Insights: Clubs are in constant competition with each other to attract members. Traditional advertising methods such as email lists may be saturated.
- Internal Ownership: Success depends on providing a price sensitive service, that provides exposure and value. Exposure and thus demand from clubs is predicated on how many users this service has.
- Value Tensions:
 - Clubs vs Students: Clubs want exposure and visibility, but students may want tailored lists of clubs that may be interested to them.

- Clubs vs Investors: Clubs want cheap and price-sensitive exposure, which may not be the most profitable pricing model (investors won't like this).

User Journey - Investors

User Scenario and Goals

- Name: Y Combinator
- Backstory, Values & Motivations: Y Combinator (YC) is a world-renowned Venture Capital Firm and Incubator based in San Francisco. They admit startups into their Winter, Spring, and Summer batches, 3-month long programs where YC provides guidance, leadership, and capital.
 - Y Combinator is backed by its investors (limited partners), and is therefore bound by fiduciary duty (YC must do everything in their power to make its investors' money). In general, YC seeks to back unicorns (startups that grow rapidly and become valued at \$ 1 billion or more).

User Actions, Thoughts, and Emotions

- YC's primary goal is to find, back, and scale startups that they can exit for a large profit. Therefore, most of their recommendations stem from the goal of generating outsized returns for their investors.
 - This may present a value tension with other stakeholders in our project. Investors may be motivated to push profits by charging customers and users more (increase advertising costs, upsell through subscription prices). Owners, users, and customers likely want this to be a widespread, valuable product. Users would be opposed to a subscription cost, and customers would want advertising costs to be as low as possible. Owners may wish to monetize, but may be driven by the "popularity" benefits of creating a campus-wide app.
- Additionally, it's important to note that investors like YC manage a large number of startups. According to their [Founding Principles](#): "YC's value is the number of startups we help times how much we help them. Make both factors surprisingly big, and the product will be surprising squared."
 - This implies that they may not have enough manpower to advise hundreds of startups per batch, or that their feedback (especially in group settings or speaker events) may be quite generalized. Since their goal is to back as many scalable startups as possible, their input may clash with the goals and specific needs of owners and consumers.

Takeaways: Opportunities, Insights, Internal Ownership

- If backed by YC or another investor, tensions may arise between key stakeholders.
 - Users and investors directly clash – users want this app to be a cost-free product, investors want this to reach as many people as possible at the highest cost.
- A key consideration for this project is whether or not this is a VC-backed startup, and whether or not outside capital is needed.

- As for insights, an investor like YC may help rapidly scale this business so that it can reach other campuses and even the real world.